Tianlu Zhang

737-342-5111 | tianlu.zhang@utexas.edu | Linkedin | Google Scholar

SUMMARY

- Five-year background in quantitative & qualitative research methodology, statistics, and human-centered research.
- Proficient in defining business problems, data mining, predictive modeling, and solution proposal.
- Rich experience in communicating with academic and industrial partners and collaborating cross-functionally.
- Expert in leading multiple projects simultaneously and mentoring.

EDUCATION

The University of Texas at Austin — Austin, TX, USA
Ph.D. in Developmental Psychology & M.S. in Statistics — *expected 06/2027*
Coursework: Mathematical Statistics, Scientific Machine Learning, Regression Analyses, Multilevel Modeling

Renmin University of China — Beijing, China
M.A., Psychology — *06/2022*

Sun Yat-Sen University — Guangzhou, China
B.A., Communication — *06/2019*

EXPERIENCE

The University of Texas at Austin — 08/2023 - Present
Graduate Research Assistant — *Austin, TX, USA*

- Defined and scoped complex research questions based on **self-reported and biological longitudinal data** to study how contextual stress and family dynamics impact adolescent physiological (salivary cortisol) & mental health.
- Conducted **multilevel/multivariate analysis**, built **linear/trajectory/machine learning models**; translated findings into actionable insights through peer-reviewed publications (8 published; 4 under review).
- Addressed inconsistent daily stress-cortisol findings by innovatively modeling interactions between within- and between-person stress levels, showing how baseline stress exposure shapes responses to sudden stress increases.
- Contributed to two national-level grant applications, including drafting aims and research strategy sections, **cleaning ecological momentary assessment data**, performing **Monte Carlo–based power analyses**.
- Coordinated 5+ ongoing projects and mentored 2 undergraduate students; served on the **departmental statistics committee** and led two years of workshops on **power analysis** and **data visualization in R**.

Tencent — *06/2021 - 06/2023*
UX Researcher — *Shenzhen, China*

- Thrive in a fast-paced environment, providing quantitative & qualitative research support to 2 product teams.
- Led **10+ quantitative & qualitative research projects** for Mobile QQ and QQ Metaverse, generating actionable insights to inform product improvements, user growth strategies, and within-platform integration.
- Identified and explained 70% user inactivity in the QQ Metaverse portal by creating **user funnels integrating user survey and behavioral data**, informing feature exposure strategies and UI optimizations.
- **Diagnosed critical loading bugs** in the QQ Metaverse **AI render engine** by integrating users' behavioral and survey data, helping AI render engine applied to the product.
- Explored user perceptions and acceptance of the **AIGC avatar** feature through **in-depth interviews**, identifying integration strategies that balance user experience and design productivity.
- Supported an **in-person usability test** for a mobile game prototype, observing real-time user behavior to identify pain points; facilitated a follow-up **focus group** to synthesize user suggestions and inform design iteration.

Austin Water — *05/2025 - 08/2025*
Data Science Intern — *Austin, TX, USA*

- Led a project aiming to build water use and conservation benchmarks for student housing. Collaborated with water conservation team to define research scope, break down project stages, and create a feasible plan.
- Applied **DBSCAN clustering** to 8 years of usage data from 10 properties, uncovering distinct consumption patterns across housing types.
- Presented findings to stakeholders, leading 8 additional properties to join the project and expanding dataset access for the next stage.

SKILLS

Analytical Techniques: (M)ANOVA, Simple/Multiple regression, GLM, Multilevel modeling, Structural Equation Modeling, Time series, Machine Learning models (Decision Trees/Random Forests/XGboost/Clustering/PCA)
Softwares: R (tidyverse/bruceR/ggplot2/caret), Python (NumPy/Pandas/Matplotlib/sklearn), MySQL, Tableau